

Penne with roasted eggplant, peppers, and feta cheese

This is a small dish, perfect for an intimate dinner for two. Eggplant makes an outstanding ingredient in pasta sauce. It's smoky, silky, and has an excellent mouthfeel. This sauce is made with roasted red peppers, feta cheese, and oregano. Roasting eggplant is surprisingly easy and creates a taste that I find more **appealing** than many other methods of cooking eggplant.

1 pound eggplant [500g]

¼ cup pine nuts [30g]

1 medium onion, chopped

3 tablespoons olive oil

2 garlic cloves, minced

2 roasted red peppers, homemade or jarred

½ pound penne [250g]

¼ cup crumbled feta cheese [30g]

2 tablespoons coarsely chopped fresh oregano

Salt and freshly ground pepper

Splash of fresh lemon juice

1. Preheat the oven to 400°F [200°C]. **Pierce** the eggplant several times with the tip of sharp knife. Place in an uncovered baking dish and roast for 45 to 60 minutes, or until the eggplant is very fragrant and collapses on its own or easily with a squeeze. Slice in half and let cool, then scoop out the meat and coarsely chop it.
2. While the eggplant is cooking, in a large dry skillet, **toast** the pine nuts over medium heat, tossing constantly, until they are lightly browned, about 3 minutes. Remove and set aside.
3. In the same pan, **cook** the onion in 1½ tablespoons of the olive oil over medium-high heat until lightly browned, 5 to 7 minutes.

4. Put the onion, garlic, roasted peppers, cooked eggplant, and remaining oil in a food processor. **Pulse** several times until you achieve a nice chunky consistency. Return the sauce to the pan.
5. Bring at least 4 quarts [4L] salted water to a vigorous boil. **Add** the pasta and stir immediately and often until the water returns to a boil. Cook until the pasta is al dente (slightly resistant to the bite), then drain quickly into a colander. Shake out the water completely.
6. When the pasta is nearly done, **reheat** the sauce over very low heat. Stir in the feta cheese and oregano. Season generously with salt and pepper. Add a splash of lemon juice and toss with the warm pasta.

SERVES 2

